Week 05 — Before You Come

100L · Semester 1 · Code Editor / IDE · Preparation: 35 minutes

Same words, better tools

Last week you typed commands into a terminal. This week you move into a **code editor**: a program built for writing code, with colours, suggestions, search across files, a terminal inside it and tools for finding mistakes. You will set it up and open your first page in the browser. Class lasts **2 hours**; this preparation happens before class and is not graded.

> **Bring:** your laptop and charger if available, a notebook, a pen and these downloaded notes. No laptop? Tell the tutor so you can take a turn on a shared machine. VS Code is free; no account, sign-in or purchase is needed.

1. Write in the plainest editor · 8 minutes

1. **(laptop)** Open the plain text editor that came with your computer: **Notepad** on Windows, **TextEdit** on macOS (choose **Format** → **Make Plain Text** first), or **Text Editor** on Linux.
2. Type these three lines exactly, including the spaces at the start of the second line:

```
Monday: Jollof rice
    Tuesday: Beans
Wednesday: Amala
```

3. Save it as `menu.txt` inside the `edupoint-week04-practice` folder you made last week, or in your home folder if that folder is gone. Close the editor and reopen the file. Did anything change?
4. **(paper)** Answer: what would help you if this file had 500 lines and one mistake hidden in it? Write two wishes, such as “show line numbers”.

Record: editor used _____ · saved in folder _____ · wish 1 _____ · wish 2 _____

No laptop? Do step 4 for a 500-line shopping list written on paper.

2. Read with a question · 15 minutes

Read in this order and stop at the boundaries below. You do not need to install anything.

1. **MDN —** Code editors (10 min). Read “What code editors are available?” and “Basic code editor functionality”. In “Enhancing your code editor with extensions”, read the first two paragraphs only. **Skip** installing Prettier and changing its settings: in class you will use VS Code's built-in formatter. The examples are JavaScript, which you learn next semester; look at their shape, not their meaning. **Question:** Which three features does a code editor give you that Notepad does not?
2. **VS Code docs —** User interface (5 min). Read only the first part, up to and including the labelled picture of the window. **Skip** everything about Chat, agents, Copilot and source control (Git arrives in week 11). **Question:** Which area of the window will hold the terminal?

3. Know what the first screen asks · 5 minutes

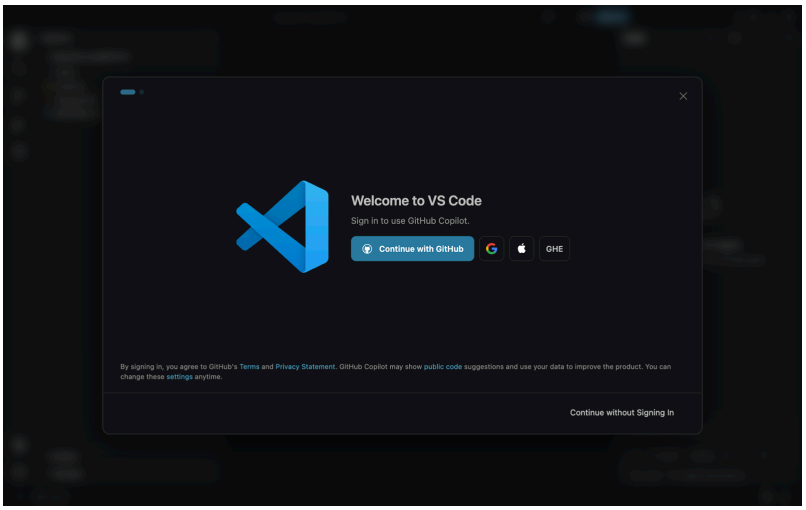


Figure 1. The first screen of a fresh VS Code 1.144 on macOS. Windows and Linux show the same dialog. Original screenshot for this workbook.

New copies of VS Code start by offering an AI assistant called GitHub Copilot. At 100L you build skills **unaided**, so in class you will choose **Continue without Signing In** and then switch the AI features off. Find that link in Figure 1 now and circle it on paper.

4. Check VS Code opens · 5 minutes

1. **(laptop)** In week 4 you checked that VS Code launches. Open it again from the Start menu, Applications folder or app menu.
2. If Figure 1 appears, choose **Continue without Signing In**, then close the next screen. If it does not appear, VS Code has been opened on this device before; that is fine.
3. Find the version: **Help** → **About** on Windows and Linux, **Code** → **About Visual Studio Code** on macOS. Record the first number pair, such as `1.144`. Close VS Code.

Record: VS Code opens: yes / no · version _____ · shared device needed: yes / no

No laptop, or VS Code missing? Record that honestly. The tutor has an offline installer and a shared station; you will not fall behind.

> **Offline route:** Tasks 1, 3 and 4 need no internet. For Task 2, use this summary: a plain text editor only edits text. A **code editor** adds colours for different parts of the code, line numbers, suggestions while you type, search and replace across many files, and **extensions** that add new features. An **IDE** (integrated development environment) bundles even more, such as running and debugging programs, into one larger application. VS Code is a code editor that can grow towards an IDE through extensions.

Ready check

- I have saved and reopened a plain text file, and written two wishes for a better editor.
- I know which link to choose on VS Code's first screen, and why.
- I have recorded whether VS Code opens on my device. I have not used AI to answer the tasks.

Sources and image credit

- MDN contributors: Code editors; Microsoft: VS Code user interface. Links checked 29 October 2026.
- Figure 1: original screenshot of Visual Studio Code 1.144 (Microsoft), taken for this workbook on a clean profile with no account signed in. The activities are original.